The Anatomy of an Effective Ad

What Drives Engagement in Sponsored Social Media Content

Hailey Cho

UMSI

1. Motivation & Objectives

The Influencer Paradox

- Influencer marketing has become a dominant strategy, but as ads blend with organic posts, audience reactions are increasingly polarized.
- The Problem: Brands need efficiency, but audiences experience "Ad Fatigue."
- Core Question: "Why do some ads work while others cause fatigue?"

Research Approach

- To answer this, I conducted a Bidirectional Analysis combining two perspectives:
- Content View: What specific features (e.g., caption length, sentiment) boost engagement?
- Audience View: Which types of audience/creator clusters are most responsive to ads?

2. Data & Preprocessing pipeline

Data Acquisition

- Source: Multimodal Post Attentive Profiling Dataset (Images + Text + Metadata).
- Gap Filling (Web Scraping): Conducted Instagram Web Scraping to extract current follower counts.

Preprocessing & Feature Engineering

- Cleaning: Removed features with excessive NaNs and irrelevant metadata.
- Translation: Converted multi-language comments/captions into English using *GoogleTranslator*.
- Sentiment Analysis: Applied *Twitter-roBERTa-base* to extract sentiment scores from text.
- Text Analysis: Applied *TF-IDF* to extract key terms from captions.
- Normalization: Normalized Engagement Rate (Likes + Comments / Followers) for fair comparison.

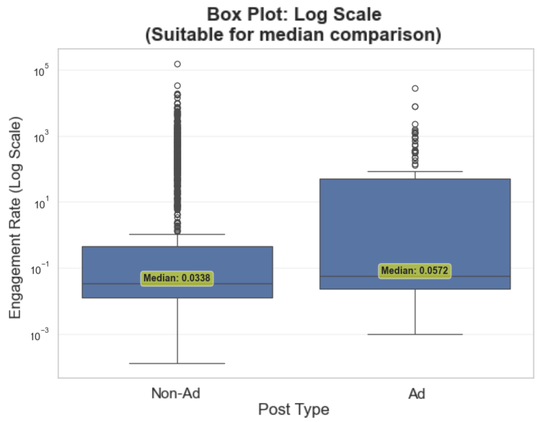
3. The Core Analysis

[Part 1] Content Perspective: What Drives Engagement?

"Does the 'Sponsored' label kill engagement? No. Content quality matters more."

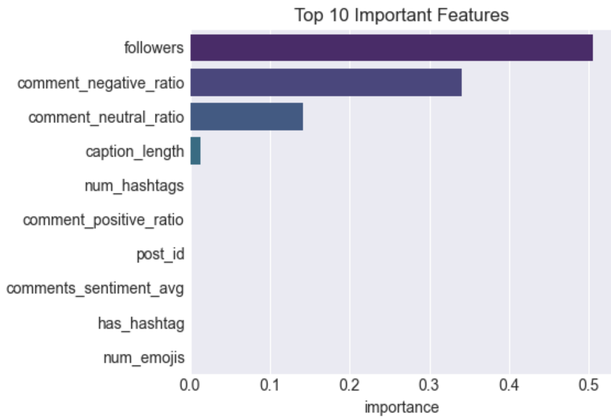
1. Engagement rates in Ad vs. Non-Ad

- Observation: A statistical comparison (T-test) between Sponsored and Non-Sponsored posts showed no significant difference in engagement rates ($p > 0.05$).
- Insight: Being "Sponsored" is not a penalty.



2. Predictive Modeling: Baseline vs. Decision Tree

- Baseline Model: Logistic Regression (Used as a benchmark).
- Final Model: Random Forest Classifier (Selected for superior performance and non-linear feature importance analysis).

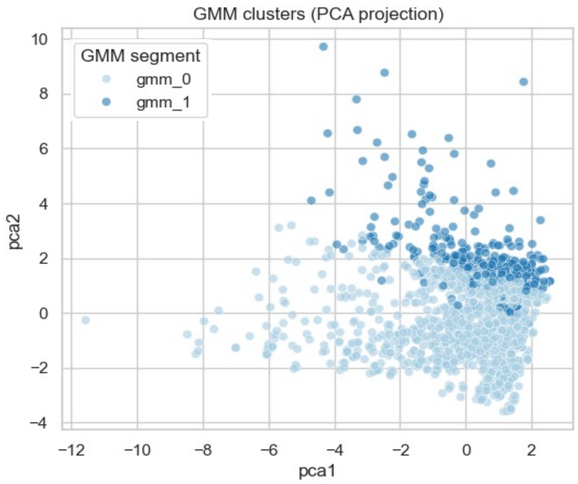


[Part 2] Audience Perspective: Who Responds How?

"Audiences are not uniform. Two distinct response patterns emerged."

1. Clustering Analysis

Using Gaussian Mixture Models (GMM), I segmented the audience based on engagement behavior and creator metadata.



2. The Two Clusters

(1) Cluster 0: The "Emotional" Responder

- Responds to : Short captions, lifestyle photos.
- Dominant keywords: Love, Cute, Beautiful.
- Reaction: Stable high engagement with emotional comments (e.g., “Love this!”, “So cute 😍”).

(2) Cluster 1: The "Pragmatic" Responder

- Responds to: Long narratives, detailed product reviews.
- Dominant keywords: Think, Want, Just.
- Reaction: Lower engagement rate, but comments indicate purchase intent (e.g., “Where to buy?”, “Price?”).

4. Key Insights

1. Sponsorship Labels Do Not Reduce Engagement

- Evidence: T-test results ($p > 0.05$) show no statistical difference in engagement between Ad and Non-Ad posts.
- Users don't care if it's an ad. They care if it's boring.

2. Shorter Captions Lead to Higher Engagement

- Evidence: In the Random Forest model, Caption Length is the #1 negative factor. As text gets longer, engagement drops.
- Mobile users don't read essays. Keep it under 3 lines.

3. "Likes" Do Not Equal "Purchase Intent"

- Evidence: Cluster 1 shows lower engagement rates but higher purchase-related comments ("Price?", "Where to buy?") compared to the high-engagement Cluster 0 (Simple praise).
- Low engagement isn't always bad. It can signal a shift from "fandom" to "commerce."

4. Interaction Features Boost Reach

- Evidence: Emojis and Mentions (@) are top positive predictors of success.
- Ads that look like a "conversation" (tagging, emotion) perform better than static announcements.